College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

Vol. 40, No. 6 **February 2026**

Admissions Watch

Arizona Inaugural EA Cohort. The U. of Arizona in Tucson attracted nearly 25,000 applications for its inaugural Early Action admissions cycle which replaced the university's former rolling admissions process. Students who met the November 1 Early Action deadline received priority consideration for merit scholarships and admission to the W.A. Franke Honors College.

Lehigh U. is Up While Others are Down. For the Class of 2030, Lehigh U. in Pennsylvania received 20,441 applications, a record. This is all the while other colleges in Pennsylvania are struggling.

"It is a wonderful time to be at Lehigh and the application numbers reflect that," Dan Warner, vice provost for admissions and financial aid, said. "This new record high is especially notable because it comes in the first year of the "demographic cliff"—an extended period of sharp decline in the number of 17 year olds across the U.S. applying to college. It is very gratifying that while there are fewer students of age to apply to colleges, more of them are choosing to apply to Lehigh….

"This is a time of great momentum for Lehigh," Warner added. "Our increased research footprint has elevated us to the R1 tier, the United Nations has given us ECOSOC status. We have added impactful research centers and academic programs, our placement results continue to be excellent year after year, and our alumni are receiving recognition for advances in their fields."

MIT Accepted 5.5 percent of Early Applicants to the Class of 2030. The Massachusetts Institute of Technology received 11,883 early applications with an acceptance rate of 5.5 percent. Some 7,738 applicants were deferred, 2,703 were rejected, and 787 withdrew their applications, according to *The Tech,* which added that the number of early action applicants declined about 1.4 percent from the previous year's figure of 12,053. Meanwhile, the number of admitted applicants decreased by 9.2 percent from last year, from 721 to 655. This year's early action acceptance rate was one of the more competitive in recent memory. For comparison, the Class of 2029's early action acceptance rate sat at 6 percnt while the Class of 2028's was 5.3 percent.

Northwestern Admitted More Than Half of New Class ED. Northwestern U. in Evanston, Illinois, received more than 5,600 Early Decision applications for its Class of 2030, a seven percent decrease from last year, dean of undergraduate admission Liz Kinsley wrote to college counselors. About 16 percent of them will be first-generation college students. According to *The Daily Northwestern*, more than half of the new class was admitted ED.

Santa Clara Admits 451 ED I Students. Santa Clara U. in California, founded in 1851, attracted 12,150 Early Decision I applications this year from all 50 States and 76 countries, slightly more than last year's record. About 50 percent of the applicants were admitted to the beautiful 106-acre campus located in Silicon Valley.

Admitted students includes 1,600 first-generation college students, 41 percent of whom speak a second language. About 51 percent of them come from outside California. Admitted students posted 3.87 unweighted high school GPA's. More than 500 are Pell-eligible students, more than 70 came from Cristo Rey high schools and ten are Posse Scholars.

"These emerging thinkers, innovators and community leaders represent the next generation poised to shape the future, both here at Santa Clara University and in the greater world," said Eva Blanco Masias, vice president

continued on page 4

Financial Matters

Access Asheville. The U. of North Carolina Asheville has extended its popular Access Asheville financial aid program to include students from South Carolina, Georgia, Tennessee and Virginia. In-state students can save as much as $7,501, while out-of-state students can save up to $14,849 for the 2025-2026 academic year.

BearCat Affordability Grant. The U. of Cincinnati announced its BearCat Affordability Grant to provide tuition-free college for students from Ohio families who make less than $75,000 a year.

"This grant program will be transformational for students, families and for this region," said Jack Miner, vice provost for enrollment management. "Despite their dreams and years of hard work, college is just out of reach for so many students and families. This grant will make dreams a reality for literally thousands of students."

Cal State Channel Islands Tuition Promise. California State U. Channel Islands, located in Ventura County between Los Angeles and Santa Barbara, guarantees eligible California residents entering their first year or as transfer students that tuition and mandatory fees will be fully covered.

Saint Louis U.'s Free Tuition. Saint Louis U., a Jesuit university, now offers free tuition to students from families who earn no more than $60,000 per year and have assets of $50,000

continued on page 2

INSIDE

- **Financial Matters**
- **Enrollment Trends**
- **Books, Scholarships**
- **Curriculum Capsules**
- **And… News You Can Uses**

COLLEGE BOUND: Publisher/Editor: **R. Craig Sautter**, DePaul University; Chief Operating Officer: **Sally Reed.** Production: Design|Americom WVA.
COLLEGE BOUND is published monthly, ten times a year. See, **http://www.collegeboundnews.com;** Inquiries should be directed to P.O. Box 6536, Evanston, IL 60204; **773-262-5810.** **Facebook @collegeboundnews; collegeboundnews@gmail.com; Twitter/X @cbnewsletter**

Enrollment Trends

Final Fall Enrollment Report. This month, the final fall enrollment trends were released by the National Student Clearinghouse Research Center. Results were compiled from data submitted by 97 percent of Title IV degree-granting institutions in the U.S.

In Fall 2025, 19.4 million students enrolled in post-secondary institutions, 16.2 million undergraduates and 3.2 million graduate students. That compares with 19.2 million college students last year or a 1 percent increase, and a 1.2 undergraduate gain.

Growth in undergraduate enrollment was driven by a 3.0 percent increase in community colleges, compared to a 1.4 percent increase at public four-year colleges. Freshman enrollment remained relatively stable this fall at -0.2 percent. Public four-year institutions experienced a 1.9 percent increase in freshman enrollment, while private four-year institutions saw declines of 10,000 students.

Trump Administration Does Not Appeal Judge's DEI Decision. Lawyers for the U.S. Dept. of Ed have withdrawn their appeal of the August 2025 ruling by U.S. District Judge Stephanie Gallagher that blocked enforcement of President Trump's one-year-old "Dear Colleague letter."

The Dept. of Ed's letter banned colleges and universities from "using race in decisions pertaining to admissions, hiring, promotion, compensation, financial aid, scholarships, prizes, administrative support, discipline, housing, graduation ceremonies and all other aspects of student, academic, and campus life."

Gallagher ruled that the letter was too vague, violated the First Amendment and failed to follow proper federal administrative "notice and comment" procedures. She wrote, "The government did not merely remind educators that discrimination is illegal: it initiated a sea change in how the Department of Education regulates educational practices and classroom conduct, causing millions of educators to reasonably fear that their lawful, and even beneficial, speech might cause them or their schools to be punished."

As a result of the Dept. of Ed letter, the *Los Angeles Times* quoted one professor who said that at "dozens of college campuses across the nation, websites have been purged of mentions of DEI or diversity, DEI-related positions have been eliminated or changed or students have lost access to culturally-themed dorms focused on Black, Latino and LGBTQ+ students."

Yet the conservative *The College Fix* charged that "while many universities did close their DEI offices, a large chunk opted to rename or revamp them and kept a lot of the same employees and goals."

Some DEI defenders believe the Trump administration's apparent surrender is simply "a tactical retreat to prevent a higher court from issuing a sweeping precedent that could permanently limit how the president can use the threat of yanking federal funding to influence policy."

However, Judge's Gallahger's ruling reversing the anti-DEI policies continues to be "law of the land." ■

FINANCIAL MATTERS

continued from page 1

or less. "This program reflects the promise we make to students and families that costs should not stand in the way of talent, potential or purpose," Marie Cox, SLU's interim vice president for enrollment management, told stlpr radio. Currently, undergraduate tuition is about $56,960.

Saint Michael's C. New Initiative. Thanks to a new $1 million gift, Saint Michael's C. in Colchester, Vermont, will make the school "cheaper." The new initiatives aim to reduce tuition with a new out-of-state flagship tuition rate, a new commuter tuition option for local students and increased the access for Vermont households making under $100,000.

Virginia Could Lose $23 Million Due to International Student Disruptions. The Commonwealth of Virginia is on pace to lose $23 million compared to last year due to visa bans and disruptions in the application process for international students. According to the *Virginia Mercury,* the state received $893.5 million from more than 23,000 international students during the 2024-2025 academic year.

"If we continue to find ourselves in the situation where international students are not wanting to come here anymore, and they're choosing to either stay home or go to another international destination... we need to be out there if we want to have any chance of trying to turn the ship around," said Rachel Banks, director of public policy at NAFSA: Association of International Educators.

Yale Free Under $200,000. Yale C. announced that it will be tuition-free for students from families earning less than $200,000. "I'm thrilled that Yale is making this important investment in affordability," said Jeremiah Quinlan, dean of undergraduate admission and financial aid. "With this announcement, we reiterate and reinforce Yale's commitment to ensuring that cost will never be a barrier between promising students and a Yale College education." ■

CURRICULUM CAPSULES

UAlbany Nursing. The U. of Albany, part of the State University of New York System and Albany Med Health System, announced a new nursing degree program to address the ongoing shortage of nurses in hospitals across New York state. The four-year program will lead to a Bachelor of Science degree. Students will complete classroom and lab work at UAlbany and rigorous clinical work alongside practicing nurses at Albany Med Health System facilities.

Dayton's Flyer Nest Launches Businesses. The U. of Dayton's Capstone course, Flyer Nest, helps students develop scalable business ideas they can continue after graduation. The program partners with the Ohio Entrepreneurial Services Provider program and the Ohio Third Frontier Technology Validation and Startup Fund. So far, the program has educated 12 teams totaling about 70 students. Each team develops a single business idea and tries to get it to fly.

Vanderbilt and California College of the Arts. Due to declining enrollment and financial problems, the California C. of the Arts announced that it will complete operations at the end of the 2026-2027 academic year after 120 years of educating students. Vanderbilt U. then will become owner of its campus and will establish undergraduate and graduate programs, including art and design programs.

"Vanderbilt will honor CCA's longstanding creative mission and maintain a strong presence for art and design education in the Bay Area," CCA's president David Howse wrote his school's community.

Vanderbilt to Build a West Palm Beach Campus. Vanderbilt U., with its main campus in Nashville, has become a "multicampus university." Last month, it also announced plans to build a graduate campus in West Palm Beach, Florida, for business, data science, artificial intelligence and engineering programs.

Plans also include "semester away opportunities for Vanderbilt's undergraduates in Nashville," executive training and lifelong learning opportunities for local residents. The new campus is now in the fund-raising stage.

P.S. Medical Schools and GPAs. "Most Med schools will want a minimum of a 3.6 overall GPA and 3.5 science GPA, but this is a bare minimum," Holly Proffitt, a medical school admissions consultant for Blueprint Prep, a test prep and training provider, told WTOP News in Chevy Chase, Maryland. ■

The Counselor's Corner

New Impacts on Admissions

China's Overseas Admissions Exam. In order to ensure the quality of international students who seek to study at Chinese universities, China has introduced a standardized admissions exam. The China Scholastic Competency Assessment begins this year and is compulsory for recipients of Chinese government scholarships.

"This is more about the shift in focus away from quantity to quality, which is happening all over the world," Richard Coward, CEO at Global Admissions, told the *Times Higher Education*.

"Previously, China had the target of 500,000 students. Now the target is towards world class universities by 2050 with the double first-class initiative. This change aims to make all international applicants have the same standards so they'll be able to follow the education at Chinese universities and so they are at least at the same level as local students."

Gerald Postiglione, professor emeritus at the University of Hong Kong, told the paper, "Students who have already studied in Chinese, or who come from systems with stronger mathematics preparation, may find it easier to meet the requirements."

Connecticut's Automatic Admission. Last year, more than 19,000 Connecticut students received an admissions offer through the Connecticut Automatic Admissions Program. High school seniors must post a weighted GPA of 3.0 or unweighted GPA of 2.75 to receive an offer from participating colleges and universities.

Does H.S. Grade Inflation Undermine Test-Free Admissions? A U. of California, San Diego study group found a 30-fold increase in students arriving without college level math skills since the school eliminated SAT/ACT admissions test requirements in 2020. UC San Diego had to revamp remedial math and writing courses to include elementary school arithmetic and composition.

The working group's report warned that "Admitting large numbers of underprepared students risks harming those students and straining limited instructional resources." Critics say that the skills gap requires greater investment in K-12 schools that fail to adequately prepare students.

Economic Diversity Replacing Affirmative Action. Elite universities are turning to economic diversity to replace strategies of affirmative action after the Supreme Court outlawed the practice two years ago, the January 6 *Los Angeles Times* reported.

"America's top campuses remain crowded with wealth, but some universities have accelerated efforts to reach a wider swath of the country, recruiting more in urban and rural areas and offering free tuition for students whose families are not among the highest earners," the paper concluded.

For example, "At Princeton University, this year's freshman class has more low-income students than ever. One in four are eligible for federal Pell Grants, which are scholarships reserved for students with the most significant financial need. That is a leap from two decades ago, when fewer than 1 in 10 were eligible." Yale, Duke, Johns Hopkins and MIT all set enrollment records for Pell-eligible students in the last two years.

The paper added, "Two years ago, Amherst College in Massachusetts made tuition free for students in the bottom 80 percent of U.S. earnings. It also started covering meals and housing for those below the median income, and it stopped prioritizing children of alumni and donors in admissions decisions. Since then, low-income enrollment has risen steadily, reaching 1 in 4 new students this year."

Pennsylvania Enacts Universal FAFSA Policy. Pennsylvania became the 14th state to require graduating seniors to fill out the Free Application for Federal Student Aid. Despite evidence that completing the form increases the number of Pell Grant students who enroll in college, both Louisiana and New Hampshire became the first states to repeal their universal requirements.

Admissions Offices Swamped with New Reporting Requirements. According to *The Hechinger Report*, "almost 2,200 colleges and universities nationwide now are scrambling to comply by March 18 with the new federal reporting requirement, formally known as the Admissions and Consumer Supplement or ACTS." It requires schools to gather seven years of admissions data, broken down by race, sex, grades, SAT or ACT scores and family income.

"By all accounts, it's a ton of work, and at small institutions, the task falls largely on a single administrator or even the registrar. Failure to submit the data can bring steep fines and, ultimately, the loss of access to federal aid for students." ■

COUNSELOR'S BOOKSHELF

The Anxious Generation by Jonathan Haidt; Penguin; ISBN13: 9781802063271; $30. Haidt argues that brains and social development of young people have been profoundly altered by the sudden replacement of realworld play with digital engagement. This shift, he argues, contributes to greater social deprivation, increased sleep disturbances, attention fragmentation and addictive patterns linked to constant mobile use. He explores implications for colleges.

Lifting the Veil on Enrollment Management: How a Powerful Industry Is Limiting Social Mobility in American Higher Education, ed. Stephen J. Burd; Harvard Education Press; ISBN13: 9781682538920; $38. An indepth critique of the enrollment management industry, a powerful network of consultants, dataanalytics firms and institutional practices which have reshaped U.S. college admissions since the 1980s.

Race, Class and Affirmative Action: College Admissions in a New Era by Julie J. Park; Harvard Education Press; ISBN13: 9798895570456; $34. This U. of Maryland professor sheds light on college admissions after the Supreme Court ruling and the ways the decision allows institutions to continue promoting racial diversity in their admissions process.

Straight from the Admissions Office by John Durante; ISBN13: 9798991954204; $19.99. Hundreds of actionable tips and insights culled from more than 250 interviews with admissions officers in his College Admissions Process Podcast.

AI in the Classroom: Adjusting to the tool that changes everything, The Chronicle of Higher Education, $69, https://store.chronicle.com.

Podcast: "College Matters" from the Chronicle, subscription series. ■

SCHOLARSHIP SCOOPS

Des Moines Dollars for Scholars. The deadline is March 31 for local Des Moines, Iowa, students to apply for one of the 10 to 16 scholarships of up to $1,000. The program has been in operation for more than 20 years.

FIU's Environmental, Coastal and Ocean Sustainability Scholarships. Florida International U. in Miami received a "transformational" gift from Wayne and Lucretia Weiner for FIU's School of Environmental, Coastal, and Ocean Sustainability. The grant funds 150 undergraduate scholarships for juniors and seniors, 70 undergraduate paid internships, 90 paid undergraduate research fellowships and 10 externships for juniors at partner institutions across the nation.

Frost School of Music and the Latin GRAMMY Cultural Foundation Scholarship. The Latin GRAMMY Cultural Foundation announced two additional scholarships at the Frost School of Music at the U. of Miami. These 2026 awards go to students who have already applied to the school and who have a "passion for Latin music and have financial limitations. The value of the scholarships range between $32,000 to $250,000.

FSU College of Business Received Historic Grant. The Florida State U. College of Business received a $65 million gift, which, among many other things, will fund a substantial number of Horatio Alger and other scholarships for undergraduate and graduate students.

"My belief in the transformative power of education and healthcare inspires me every day and I am truly excited to partner with Florida State University to help lift the College of Business to new heights," said Herbert Wertheim, the billionaire founder of Brain Power Incorporated, who gave the gift. "Together, we will empower students and future leaders to drive meaningful progress, advance innovation in health care and business, and create lasting opportunities that benefit our communities and the world."

Muscular Dystrophy Association Scholarships. Muscular Dystrophy Association scholarships support "students living with neuromuscular diseases who are currently pursuing or preparing to pursue undergraduate studies…." MDA awards merit-based scholarships of up to $5,000 per student. Applications are due March 15. See, www.mda.org/scholarship.

Virginia Tech Receives $11 Million for Engineering Scholarships. Virginia Tech received an additional $11 million to supplement an initial $15 million investment from the A. James & Alice B. Clark Foundation for engineering scholarships. Ten Clark Scholars are admitted to the College of Engineering each year with tuition, room and board and fees fully covered.

Wichita State Receives $1 Million for Need-Based Scholarships. A 1958 Wichita State U. graduate donated $1 million to support need-based scholarships in the W. Frank Barton School of Business. About 46 percent of Wichita State's undergraduates are first-generation college students, many in need of financial aid. "Our goal is to prepare students for a business world that values vision, collaboration and innovative problem-solving," said Larisa Genin, dean of the Barton School of Business. ■

NEWS YOU CAN USE

Confidence in College Plunges. According to Pew Research, the number of people who believe that college is "very important" declined from 75 percent in 2010 to just 35 percent in 2025. Despite that, the number of students who earned bachelor's degrees rose from 1.6 million in 2010 to 2 million in 2023. An individual with a bachelor's degree earns an estimated 70 percent more than a high school graduate.

Students who receive financial aid pay about 20 percent less than they did in 2015 at public four-year universities and 12 percent less at private colleges, after adjusting for inflation, noted *The Atlantic*.

Extracurriculars That Count. What extracurricular activities set students apart for admissions officers? In a May 7, 2025, Instagram post, Kate Stone, founder of Kate Stone Prep, wrote ""Showing up for ONLY school sponsored clubs or 'because it looks good' won't distinguish you in this process - it just blends you into a crowd of sameness." On November 9, she ranked high school extracurriculars on a scale from 1 to 10.

Here are some of her scores: Becoming the leader of a club with significant impact, 10/10; Winning club competitions, 10/10; Year-round sports if you're going D1, 10/10; Shadowing professionals, 10/10; Building a network of mentors, 10/10; solving a real-world problem in your community, 10/10; Playing the viola, 9/10; Taking an independent online course or college course, 8/10; Playing an instrument at a competitive state or national level, 8/10.

Volunteering with a cause you're passionate about, 7/10; Newspaper editor, 7/10; Planning your prom, 7/10; Internships, 7/10; Eagle Scout, 6/10; Student Council, 5/10; Model U.N. and debate, 5/10; Deca, 5/10; Being captain of a sport's team, 4/10; Tutoring, 4/10; Becoming the leader of a club without significant impact, 3/10; Working as a camp counselor, 3/10; Working as a lifeguard, 3/10.

Playing an instrument, 3/10; Year-round sports, 3/10; Robotics, 3/10; Playing violin, 3/10; Volunteering just to log hours, 2/10.

Purdue Tops World's 25 Best-Managed Universities. Purdue U., with main campuses in West Lafayette and Indianapolis, has been recognized as a global model in demonstrating sustained excellence over the past decade in student and faculty satisfaction, financial stability, teaching and research quality and trust in graduate outcomes, according to Organizational Excellence Specialists, a Canadian global management consulting firm. Purdue, which has frozen undergraduate tuition for the past 14 years, is one of only three U.S. universities recognized.

Others in the top ten include: the U. of Cambridge, National U. of Singapore, ETH Zurich, U. of Tokyo, U. of Melbourne, Stanford U., U. of Toronto, KU Leuven in Belgium and Seoul National University.

Reading Results. According to a new JP Morgan survey of more than 100 billionaires, reading ranks as the top habit that elite achievers have in common. However, last year, 40 percent of Americans did not read a single book. Over the past two decades, reading for pleasure has collapsed by 40 percent. Members of Generation Z, aged 18 to 29, read on average 5.8 books in 2025, the lowest of any generation, according to YouGov. ■

ADMISSIONS WATCH

continued from page 1

for enrollment management.

April 15 is Santa Clara's deadline for rolling admission or transfer students.

P.S. Tougher Than Ever. Ivy League acceptance rates have declined fivefold over the past three decades. ■

To renew your subscription, go online to www.collegeboundnews.com

Annual subscription: $59 in North America, $69 for international orders, including airmail postage. See, **www.collegeboundnews.com**

©2026 COLLEGE BOUND PUBLICATIONS, INC. All rights reserved. ISSN 1068-7912 For photocopy rights, please write the Editors.